Showing Off: From Peacocks to Selfies

Day 1 · Reading (1 of 2)

What to do: Read it aloud, one paragraph each. Stop at every blue word: can anybody explain it?

Vocabulary topic: Pride and image: peacocks and selfies
20 new words (in blue) · EEW 1, Unit 10 · read about animals and people who show off and talk about image and pride



easy parts harder parts (most new words are here)

Look at a peacock. Its **tail** is huge, blue and green, with a hundred bright “eyes”. Why does a bird need such a heavy tail? It cannot help the bird to run away from danger. The answer is simple: the male peacock wants to show that he is healthy and strong. Peacocks come from India and Sri Lanka, and the best **site** to see wild peacocks is a forest in India.

Scientists studied this for a long time. The **function** of the beautiful tail is not to fly or to **guard** the bird. Its **primary** purpose is to give a good **image** to the female birds. A bird with a bright tail has a better **chance** to find a partner. Researchers say that this **effect** is so strong that the tail grows bigger over many generations. It is a **benefit** and a danger at the same time: a heavy tail makes it harder to escape.

People do something similar. We choose nice clothes, we make our hair and we take photos of our best moments. We want other people to see a good picture of us. This is not a crime. It is human.

On social media, the picture of life often has an **immediate** effect: you post a photo and in ten minutes you can see the likes. A lot of people feel **proud** when many people like their photo. But experts say that we must **separate** real life from the picture. A photo shows only one second. Your real day also has the **rest**: the homework, the bad mood, the dinner. If you **focus** only on the image, you may forget to enjoy your life.

Be **certain** about one thing: nobody has a perfect life. Even the person with the most beautiful photos has bad days, too. Real peacocks have bad days as well: they are loud, they fight, and in the cold they hide their tails.

Showing Off: From Peacocks to Selfies

Day 1 · Reading (2 of 2)

What to do: After reading: which paragraphs were easy, which were hard? Which blue words did you know already?

In your book, Unit 10, an Ancient Greek man with 100 eyes guards a special cow. It is an **essential** job, and he does it very well, because he never sleeps with all his eyes. He rests only a few eyes at a time. But a stranger plays beautiful music, the guard falls asleep, and the cow is gone. The goddess is very angry, and she changes him into a peacock. She puts his 100 eyes on his tail. In the end he **remains** in the sky as a group of stars. It is a story about **trouble** that comes from one small mistake.

Here are some fun facts. A peacock's tail is called a train, and it can be one and a half meters long. The female is called a peahen, and the babies are called peachicks. Peacocks can fly, but only for short distances. And the colors of the tail do not come from paint: they come from tiny structures that reflect the light.

Do you know other animals that show off? The bird of paradise dances in the forest to impress a partner. The frigatebird blows up a bright red balloon on its chest. And some fish change color when they are excited. Showing off is very old.

Psychologists say that our image has two parts: the picture we show and the picture other people see. Often they are different. A very serious student may look cold, and a shy person may look unfriendly. That is why a smile and a few kind words can change your image much faster than a new jacket.

A walk in the park can show you real life. Sit on the **grass**, put your phone away and look. A real peacock walks slowly near you, and it does not care about likes. The park is not **far** from your house. Go there today and take no photo at all.

The 20 words

Day 1 · Vocabulary table · Topic: Pride and image: peacocks and selfies

What to do: Book: 4000 EEW 1, Unit 10, pages 62–65. Copy the words you do not know into the copybook.

Word	Meaning	По-русски	Example
benefit n.	a good result or advantage	польза, выгода	Sport has many benefits.
certain adj.	completely sure	уверенный; определённый	I am certain that she is right.
chance n.	a possibility; an opportunity	шанс, возможность	This is your last chance!
effect n.	a change caused by something	эффект, влияние	The medicine had a good effect.
essential adj.	absolutely necessary	необходимый, важнейший	Sleep is essential for health.
far adj./adv.	a long distance away	далеко	Is the station far from here?
focus v.	give all your attention to one thing	сосредоточиться	Focus on your work, please.
function n.	the job or purpose of something	функция	What is the function of this button?
grass n.	the green plant that covers fields	трава	The children are sitting on the grass.
guard n./v.	protect; watch over	охранник; охранять	A guard stands at the door.
image n.	the picture others have of you; a picture	изображение	The image on the screen is very clear.
immediate adj.	happening right now, without delay	немедленный	We need an immediate answer.
primary adj.	first, most important	главный; начальный	My primary goal is to pass the exam.
proud adj.	pleased about something you or others did	гордый	My parents are proud of me.
remain v.	stay in a place or a state	оставаться	Please remain in your seats.
rest n./v.	the other part; a time to relax	отдых; отдыхать	After the race, he had a rest.
separate adj./v.	keep apart; not together	отдельный; разделять	Separate the white clothes from the black ones.
site n.	a place where something is or happens	место, участок	This is the site of the new school.
tail n.	the part at the back of an animal	хвост	The dog is wagging its tail.
trouble n.	difficulty or problems	беда, проблема	He is in trouble with his teacher.

More on the topic

Day 1 · Topic: Pride and image: peacocks and selfies · more words

What to do: Choose 5 collocations to learn. Use the reserve words when a student already knows the main ones.

Collocations: words that go together

a great benefit	большое преимущество
be certain of…	быть уверенным в…
have a chance to…	иметь шанс…
a side effect	побочный эффект
an essential part	важнейшая часть
focus on…	сосредоточиться на…
a good image	хороший имидж
an immediate answer	немедленный ответ
be proud of…	гордиться…
the rest of the day	остаток дня
get into trouble	попасть в беду
sit on the grass	сидеть на траве

Phrasal verbs

show off	выпендриваться	He likes to show off his new phone.
stand out	выделяться	A peacock stands out in the forest.
look after	присматривать за	Look after your friends.
fall asleep	заснуть	The guard fell asleep.
turn into	превратиться в	The man turned into a peacock.
make up	придумать	The Greeks made up many stories.

Reserve words: for students who know the 20 already, or if you prefer another word

feather	перо	**post**	публиковать
bright	яркий	**follower**	подписчик
proud	гордый	**real**	настоящий
shy	застенчивый	**fake**	поддельный
selfie	селфи	**compliment**	комплимент

What to read next · 4000 Essential English Words

This week: **Book 1, Unit 10, "The First Peacock"**, pages 62–67. Next: **Unit 11, "Princess Rose and the Creature"**, pages 68–73. About image and an artist: **Unit 12, "The Crazy Artist"**, pages 74–79.